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Strauss' Interpretation of Xenophon's *Hiero* and its Implications for the Organization of the UHS

Both Kojève, the Hegelian, and Strauss, the classicist, agree that the contemporary world faces a pull toward universal homogenization. For Kojève, the move toward this state represents the increasing instantiation of the first and final non-tyrannical regime, the first in which *all* citizens, rather than some fraction, spontaneously recognize the same authority (i.e. each other), owing to the universal dissemination of anthropocentric wisdom. For him, the universal and homogeneous state (UHS) is the best social order. For Strauss, while all regimes are in a particular respect tyrannical, in as much as human law can never fully accord with justice itself or divine law, the UHS, “perhaps... fated to come”, would be the most comprehensive tyranny to have ever come into being, and would mark “the end of philosophy on earth” – not by the universal achievement of wisdom, but by the extermination of all philosophers (208-211). Human thought faces the appalling danger, prepared by various efforts to master nature, and in particular human nature, of being collectivized and reduced by “slow and gentle processes” (27). What accounts for this course, and its appearance as progress? The purpose of this essay is to elaborate, from Strauss' perspective, the basis of this assessment of the character of the trajectory of the contemporary world. Strauss is never fully explicit, but chooses Xenophon's *Hiero* or *Tyrannicus* to illustrate the problem. The dialogue has a special pertinence in its resemblance, on inspection, to Machiavelli's *The Prince*.¹ With Xenophon as a foundational classical thinker and Machiavelli often recognized as the founder of modern political science, a comparison of these similar

1 As well, Machiavelli frequently acknowledges his debt to Xenophon – but only to his non-Socratic works.

texts can be expected to allow one to “grasp most clearly the subtlest and indeed the decisive difference between Socratic political science and Machiavellian political science” (24). It will be this decisive difference, namely the willingness of certain wise men to encourage political men to attempt to consummate their desire for justice on earth, that results in the concrete realization of the “perpetual and universal” tyranny. Comparison of the two texts will allow further the outlining of the basic mechanisms such a regime would employ to consolidate power while disguising its nature.

According to Strauss, Xenophon's particular excellence and intention is to be seen in his emphasis on *rhetoric*, i.e. Socratic rhetoric, to an even greater extent than the *philosopher* par excellence Plato (26). The purpose of Socratic rhetoric “is to lead potential philosophers to philosophy both by training them and by liberating them from the charms which obstruct the philosophic effort, as well as to prevent the access to philosophy of those who are not fit for it” (27). This is achieved by constructing the transmission such that any teachings liable to misinterpretation by those without philosophic aptitude are couched within a more innocuous surface interpretation. Implicit in the form, then, is the idea that different teachings are appropriate for different types of person. *Hiero* shows itself as containing an unusual amount of rhetorical safeguards and as such can be expected to contain a teaching especially liable to misinterpretation by those for whom it is inappropriate. A special amount of “add[ing] and subtract[ing]” is required to lay hold of it (66). By careful accounting of the dialogue's multi-faceted symbols and action, Strauss is able to triangulate Xenophon's meaning in the *Hiero*, which ultimately regards “the true relation of rule and wisdom” (87).

1. *Hiero/Tyrannicus*

The first part of this essay is a reconstruction of Strauss' model of Xenophon's teaching in the *Hiero* – its outer aspect and inner meanings. The dialogue depicts an encounter between a tyrant and a

poet the tyrant recognizes as wise and who indeed proves to be so. This basic premise is of considerable significance. It implies a stratification, or interpretive disparity, between the discussants. The wise are more clever, i.e. more capable in argument or discourse, than the less wise. As well, the wise are privy to their own motivations but because their reasoning is opaque to the unwise so are their purposes. The more wise (or 'wise') and less wise (or 'unwise') operate on different levels of perception. The less wise, who are many, perceive only two fundamental types of person and corresponding world-view: the vulgar and gentlemanly. The vulgar opinion about tyranny is that "tyranny is bad for the city but good for the tyrant"; the gentlemanly opinion is that "tyranny is bad, not only for the city, but above all for the tyrant himself" (40). Those on the level of the unwise understand those outstanding men, the courageous man and the just man, who may not be wise, to be exemplars of gentlemanliness, but they cannot be sure about the leaning of those who possess the excellence, or power, that is wisdom. Because the vulgar believe tyranny to be the highest good, they suspect the wise of themselves aspiring to tyranny or advising those who would in return for favours. This is not so misguided a fear, for: "[b]oth the wise man and the sophist are in a sense possessors of wisdom. But whereas the sophist prostitutes wisdom for base purposes, and especially for money, the wise man makes the most noble or moral use of wisdom. The wise man is a gentleman, whereas the sophist is servile" (42). From the limited perspective of the unwise, the philosopher and the sophist are conflated and indistinguishable, and it is surmised that wise men in general may be after tyrannical power. The fact that the unwise and vulgar can't exclude the possibility that the wise man has tyrannical ambitions has special import owing to Hiero's status as a tyrant, i.e. not only as someone possessing such power, but as one who manifestly demonstrates a preference for it. The subtext of the encounter is defined by the not-wise Hiero's fear of the possible ministrations of his wise interlocutor toward the eventual capture of his throne, albeit downgraded to mere vague suspicion by the fact that the poet is only a visitor to the city (cf. 5.3). The dialogue's *logos* unfolds through this architecture; to achieve his purpose, whatever it may be,

Simonides must successfully navigate Hiero's defensive misdirections or lack of forthrightness. As well, more simply, presuming his purpose involves advising the tyrant, he must find a tactful way of suggesting a shortcoming the tyrant suffers from, since it is a delicate matter to rebuke a tyrant directly (38).

Simonides' approach is to initiate a discussion regarding the relative desirability, in terms of pleasure, of tyrannical life versus private life. His first presentation of the question emphasizes the pleasures which belong to the body. From Hiero's perspective, Simonides, wise as he is, does not have direct experience of tyrannical life; Hiero seems to have been provided with an avenue by which to mislead this wise man, and so to buffer himself from possible "contrivances". Of course, this is not actually the case: "the question itself is not of such a nature that peculiar experiences which a wise man may or may not have had (such as those which only an actual tyrant can have had) could contribute significantly to its complete answer" (37). Hiero is not sure whether Simonides is a gentleman or otherwise. Simonides' presentation of the question in terms of bodily pleasures, however, seems to indicate that he is not interested in tyrannical power per se: for "men chiefly interested in bodily pleasures are not likely to aspire to any ruling position" (49). This encourages Hiero to choose the tack he does, to "reproduce... the gentleman's image of the tyrant" (92), which will show most plainly that the tyrant is deprived of bodily pleasures and hence discourage this wise man from aspiring to tyrannical rule, while also preserving Hiero's maneuverability should Simonides merely be testing the waters with a question which appears even to Hiero to be too easy (2.5). Indeed, Simonides soon increases his menace by leaving bodily pleasures behind as trivial and pointing out that tyrants are most capable of executing great enterprises, possessing the most beautiful things, and harming enemies and helping friends – those things which seem to characterize "those who are reputed to be real men" (2.1). Hiero is committed to performing the deeper criticisms belonging to the gentleman's image. Most notably, Hiero introduces rejoinders which accord to loftier principles. Yet, Simonides, for his part,

does not demonstrate that he is impressed by the arguments; he only listens, where on previous topics he maintained a more active involvement. Simonides' only interjection is to comment that Hiero has exaggerated regarding the tyrant's inability to combine the pleasures of sleep with dangerous living. Simonides' lack of scruple, or non-gentlemanliness, is confirmed to Hiero by the discussion's third and final escalation. In spite of the moral depravities Hiero has outlined, Simonides suggests that tyranny is still desirable for its providing the tyrant with increased opportunities for honour, which he now states without equivocation as *the* quality which distinguishes “real men” (those men least like cattle) from mere “human beings” (7.3). After this blunt gesture of his non-gentlemanliness and taste for the provision enabled by tyrannical power, Hiero defends by saying that the honour deriving from tyrannical power, like the sexual pleasures deriving from tyrannical power discussed earlier under the heading of the bodily pleasures, is void because it does not come from willing subjects. At Simonides' tacit suggestion that Hiero might then abdicate his throne, in order to abandon the travails of tyranny, Hiero replies, as the climax of his performance of the gentleman's indictment, that the tyrant could never hope to repay his debts and as such is hardly better off alive than dead. At this point, the wise man has seemingly revealed himself as indeed a competitor for tyrannical rule. His dialectic has driven his tyrannical interlocutor to claim he would almost be better off committing suicide. Yet, instead of pressing Hiero further, Simonides stops and shifts course; he diagnoses Hiero's chief deficiency as his being unloved by human beings and begins to offer him advice on how to achieve this goal.

We may then summarize the function of the action Simonides has set forward, constituting the first part of the dialogue. First, he has established the shortcoming from which Hiero suffers and may now, in all propriety, direct his advice toward Hiero on this subject. Second, Simonides has demonstrated, by means of a dialectical show, his competency as an adviser to a tyrant. As a stranger, the threat Simonides poses to Hiero is limited: as such the distrust Simonides plays on in inducing Hiero to assume the gentleman's image is controlled (41). Simonides takes Hiero to the heart of the

image, in which the tyrant would seem to be nearly compelled to commit suicide, but instead of pushing him toward such an action, Simonides relents, in what is both a gesture of good intentions and a demonstration of competency in recognizing that Hiero's despair is in large part a facade (58-59). As well, Simonides shows himself to be, not an “awkward schoolmaster,” but a “hardboiled man” without moral objection to tyranny and, moreover, with sufficient political astuteness to know to intimate his lack of scruple without announcing it (53, 55-56). He shows that he is the kind of wise man who has advice that Hiero, tyrant that he is, might be able to use.

The second part of the dialogue, after the *peripetia*, consists of Simonides' advice to Hiero. Simonides' advice falls into two categories. The first category of advice regards how Hiero presents himself. The advice is that Hiero should leverage the natural prestige afforded by any position of rulership, but to bifurcate his deeds into those that “give rise to mutual regard” and those which “give rise more to mutual enmity,” and to take public responsibility for the first but to delegate or diffuse responsibility for the latter. In short, to present oneself as a ruler and to conceal the harsher aspects of tyrannical rule. This consists in (a) managing “all political things” (good arms, good discipline, horsemanship, prowess in war, justice in contractual relations, and even agriculture, and imports) as contests with prizes. This is both economical (“no articles of commerce are cheaper than what human beings purchase by means of prizes”) and serves the purpose of “keeping the subjects busy with their private concerns rather than with public affairs” (most notably, those natural enemies of the tyrant, the courageous and just) (70). Simonides first category of advice also consists in (b) maintaining the tyrant's mercenaries, the greatest aggravation to the citizens (8.10), but rebranding them as peace-keepers. As well, (c) Simonides *shows* Hiero, by himself adopting a new lexicon modeled to match the gist of his advice, to begin representing himself not as a “tyrant” but as a “ruler”, and indeed Hiero picks up on the cue (10.1). The second category of advice regards how Hiero considers himself. It is for Hiero to expand his sphere of personal agency or ownership to include the city, which involves re-

arming the citizens, and to make his contest, not against his own citizens, but against other heads of state. If Hiero follows Simonides' advice, Simonides says, he will become happy while being free from envy, while only having to relinquish tyranny in name.

The surface teaching of the dialogue is complete. To the extent that Simonides seems to have solved Hiero's problem of acquiring freely-bestowed love, and seems to share Hiero's preferences for a sort of recognition, he has shown that the life of a tyrant, or ruler as Hiero is advised to consider himself, is superior to private life. Hiero, while maintaining a facade of attacking tyranny, has manifestly demonstrated his preference for tyranny²; Simonides has apparently vindicated Hiero's taste for and strategy toward acquiring the adoration of men. At the same time, the wise Simonides has pointed out that the gentleman's criticism of tyranny is overstated – the tyrant may indeed be happy, so long as he rules prudently. In short, the dialogue seems to be “a recommendation to strive for tyrannical power, not indeed to gratify [the] desires, but to gain the love and admiration of all men by deeds of benevolence on the greatest possible scale” (30).³

A deeper meaning is revealed on critical inspection. The dialogue offers (1) “a most forceful expression of the problem of law and legitimacy”, (2) a comment on “the true relation of wisdom to rule”, and (3) a fuller typology of human beings than is understood by the unwise. First, the dialogue contains the politically inflammatory “theoretical thesis concerning tyranny” (76): that all law is essentially unjust and that the lawless tyranny, then, holds the potential for the most direct application of divine justice to earthly affairs. The *improved* tyrannical regime, far from entrenching a dreadful

2 At Simonides' suggestion that Hiero return to private life, Hiero had said that the tyrant could never repay his debts and as such is hardly better of alive than dead. Yet, he avoids the possibility that he might escape punishment by fleeing. Hiero has already mentioned the danger that he might be deposed while journeying abroad; surely a willful self-deposition would be feasible. “Hiero refuses to consider the possibility of escape from his city. He thus reveals himself as a man who is unable to live as a stranger” (57). The tyrant is, at bottom, a citizen – disposed toward local affairs.

3 Xenophon mitigates the political odiousness of this surface message by surrounding it by several ambivalent considerations: that Simonides was famous for his greed and a poet; that Hiero was not a tyrant of a Greek city; that Hiero was not a contemporary figure; that Xenophon nowhere offers evidence of a happy tyrant; that Hiero appears to be in need of consolation. Without these mitigating elements, the surface teaching of the dialogue would destroy Xenophon's defense of the wise Socrates as a good citizen and not an encourager of tyrants. As it is, it only strains it.

state of affairs for the city, would live up to Xenophon's highest political standard (72). While the ruler/tyrant's subjects do not have laws or freedom, they are still able to achieve virtue and happiness, even if only of a specific kind. That the regime has been established by force or fraud is irrelevant so long as the wise man functions as the tyrant's advisor: "Xenophon's Socrates makes it clear that there is only one sufficient title to rule: only knowledge" (74). That the regime not only meets a standard of decency, but the *highest* standard is suggested by the Socratic understanding of justice as translegal -- that *laws* may be more or less good as they try to approximate a *justice* which goes beyond the law. While law or legal justice is encumbered by general application and tradition, or the prejudices of the founders, the excellent absolute ruler may best represent translegal justice on earth by functioning as a "seeing law" (74). All regimes institute rules of conduct which attempt to approximate justice, most of which are entrenched by tradition and a constitution; yet these laws, even at their best, are not an entirely comprehensive representation. Hence, tyranny or absolute rule holds the potential of maximum fluidity for applying justice to particular situations and, so long as the ruler's hand is guided by his wise adviser, is superior in theory to rule encumbered by the insufficiencies and generalities of law. This thesis seems to endorse tyranny and as such, if presented explicitly, would serve as fodder for the persecution of philosophers. The easy misinterpretation of this teaching is the reason for the dialogue's particularly thick rhetorical defenses.

To the close observer, however, this thesis is only intended to draw attention to the problem of law, or to the essential ability to appeal from civic law to divine law or justice itself. This is because in practice the conclusion is nearly the reverse: absolute rule is almost always oppressive and volatile. The ruler's regime is only improved to the extent that he has a wise man willing to function as a shadow ruler, and that he follows and accurately implements the wise man's advice, both extremely unlikely propositions. To the extent that he does not have an appropriate adviser, or misapplies his advice, the fluidity afforded by his absolute rule only results in a more direct obscuration of justice than that

effected by law. Moreover, because of the tradition of law in cities, the figure wielding absolute power typically bears the stigma of *tyrant*, limiting his efficacy and indicating particular flaws of character. Such is the case of Hiero. He is not able to adjust his appearance since he cannot safely effect the shift of power from his mercenary bodyguards to his angry subjects (187-188). Nor is it likely Hiero would want to adjust his self-conception. Simonides tells Hiero to expand his being to include the city and to redirect his antagonism of the citizens toward other rulers (6.14). In effect, he advises Hiero to refrain from the natural compulsions of the tyrannical type to indulge the pleasures of “tak[ing] from an unwilling enemy” and enslaving and killing his subjects (1.34). First, it is possible that the despised tyrant may be unable to martial his troops toward global conquest, no matter how much he changes his attitude. Second, Hiero's disposition makes him unlikely to swallow the prospect of having to behave like a servant or relative equal to his subjects in order to effect Simonides' suggested change in perspective, or even to submit himself to the advice or “law” prescribed by the wise man at all. The only portion of Simonides' advice Hiero is likely to implement is a small specific suggestion that the tyrant ought to avoid competing in the Olympic games. Simonides' advice, whether for tyrants or young men of a tyrannical bent, is more benign and has more modest expectations than the recipient of the advice might be aware of. The problem of law and legitimacy – the theoretical thesis concerning tyranny – does not, in the end, endorse tyranny.

The second deeper teaching of the dialogue involves, beyond the surface comparison of the life of the tyrant to the private man, the comparison of the life of the ruler to the life of the wise man, and even of the life of the citizen to the life of the stranger. Hiero, the ruler who refuses to abdicate his throne at the head of his city and Simonides, the wise man who lives as a stranger, manifest different preferences. Hiero is diagnosed as “desiring to be loved by human beings”; i.e. with being passionately sought after by all human beings (8.1). Simonides demonstrates a sincere preference for honour, i.e., with being praised only by “those who are free in the highest degree”. Simonides himself is concerned

with the defining element of a real man, but when advising Hiero he expands the concern to love in general, i.e. the common denominator between honour and sexual pleasure (7.5-6). Simonides says that if Hiero follows his advice Hiero will be loved by his subjects and admired by all; even Hiero's enemies will acknowledge his greatness, but only his subjects will love him. Love, as against praise or admiration, depends on proximity – on both nearness of time and place, or a sense of personal interest. As well, the ruler only becomes admired by services rendered, by becoming beneficent. Simonides indicated two kinds of action that “give rise to mutual regard” – “to teach what is best” and “to praise and honor the man who achieves this in the noblest way” (9.2.); the ruler can only perform the latter function, depending on the wise man for the former. The wise man does not need to be a servant to be admired, “the admiration which he gains is essentially a tribute to his perfection” (90). Thus the preference for love reflects the proximal existence of the citizen while a preference for honour reflects the cosmopolitan existence of the stranger.

Simonides' polite generalization of honour (the real man's pleasure) to its root in love when speaking of Hiero's deficiency indicates the wise man's assessment that Hiero is preoccupied with the sensual pleasures. The tyrant attempts to “get more” pleasure by means of fraud or force; yet this pleasure can only be properly consummated with a willing partner, and so the tyrant, at least the prudent one, will be forced to become beneficent. The beneficent tyrant – i.e. the ruler – at best is a servant, rewarded with praise from the many. “The ruler cannot escape envy but by leading a life of perpetual business, care and trouble. The ruler whose specific function is “doing” or “well-doing” has to serve all his subjects. Socrates, on the other hand, whose specific function is “speaking” or discussing, does not engage in discussion except with those with whom he likes to converse. The wise man alone is free” (84). The wise are not interested in the tedium of guiding politics, i.e. “the total direction of public affairs” (205). It remains to be discussed how this preference is reflected in their engagements with the political communities they encounter.

Third, by establishing this relation of wisdom to rule, the dialogue provides the means to derive a typology of human beings. There is a categorical difference separating Simonides and Hiero reflected in how they choose to live. Hiero is caught in a cycle of co-dependency; he wants authentic love – the common element activating both admiration and the most fulfilling sexual encounters – but to achieve this he must become a benefactor or servant. He is separated from the common stock – the ordinary citizens who acknowledge tyranny as the most choice-worthy life, and even the ordinary gentlemen who espouses allegiance to the proximal realm that is the fatherland – only by the degree of his success; his *goal* is the same. All such human beings desire in the main to be loved by all human beings. The tyrant-ruler is the amplification of the ordinary (vulgar) citizen; the decent statesman is the amplification of the ordinary gentleman. The latter are closer to their goal than the former since they are predisposed to what the former require a wise adviser to convince them of – that to be loved one must first show love or do service. In any case, all of these types share the common bond of being unable to penetrate the higher atmosphere and motivations of the wise men.

There are two types of wise men – the sophist, and the philosopher – and neither is interested in the life of the ruler. Simonides' chief concern is being honoured or praised by those qualified few who are “free in the highest degree.” The unwise Hiero and the ordinary citizen who aspires to tyranny have a worldview which can be expressed purely in terms of an economy of pleasure. By contrast, despite a possible lack of scruple, Simonides is not a hedonist, since he recognizes a threshold -- the quality of being a “real man” -- which cannot be accounted for in terms of pleasure: “What he praises most highly is pleasant indeed, but pleasure alone does not define it sufficiently; it is pleasant on a certain level, and that level is determined, not by pleasure, but by the hierarchy of beings” (95-96). This is the distinction which Plato's Socrates uses to punish Callicles when he attempts to hold together the indiscriminate accrual of pleasures with a pretense of superiority; because all men have relatively equal claim to pleasures, if, for example, courage is to be superior to cowardice, it must not be so in terms of mere

pleasure – one must account for some kind of external natural limit or order. Simonides does not make this mistake. Simonides recognizes some sort of natural standard, which distinguishes the real men from the cattle, but the extent to which the influence of this standard otherwise impinges on Simonides' calculus of pleasure is unclear. Simonides does not respect the “fatherland” or the political community in which one is raised. He lives as a stranger, and advises Hiero to do the same in effect by “consider[ing] his fatherland to be [his] estate,” i.e. expanding the sphere of his being to contain the city (11.14). The preference of individualism to civic participation is tantamount to preferring oneself to others – abandoning one's community. The preference would seem at first glance to be a corollary of the “theoretical thesis concerning tyranny”; if human law is inferior to justice proper, the wise man would seem to be motivated to escape the city and live a cosmopolitan existence in a global community. This suggestion must be reconciled with the fact that Socrates, the archtypical classic philosopher, lived as a citizen-philosopher. Why do some wise men choose to live differently than others?

We said that love, i.e. a kind of willingly given praise from others, is the common denominator behind sexual pleasures and honour. As the emphasis shifts from sexual pleasures toward honour (with Hiero inbetween, Simonides near the point of honour), the character of the praise shifts from the sensual, bestowed upon those considered to be one's own or one's benefactor, to the more dispassionate, reserved for the excellent simply. Those who recognize and care about honour are discerning as to its source – it must come from competent judges, i.e. fellow wise men. As mentioned above, this scale indicates a shift from citizenship to cosmopolitanism. The curiosity at hand is that certain wise men find ground upon which to live as a good citizens, or rather to balance the duties of citizenship with the duties implied by attention to problems which exceed explanation in terms of pleasure alone.

Strauss identifies the pivot determining the type of wise man as “one's manner of understanding the order which is not man-made and which is only confirmed by the law” (105). Hiero and Simonides

both are not gentlemen and both are silent on the role of piety in determining the best course of action. “The tyrant, and indeed any absolute ruler, may be said to usurp honors rightfully belonging to the gods alone” (104), and the only thing preventing Simonides from contriving to usurp tyrants is that he has no interest in the praise of the many. Hiero seems to use the expression “the gods” less as a gesture indicating a beneficent or purposive origin of natural order, and more as an anthropomorphized expression of the forces of chance (105). If human law seems to exist in praise or cooperation with divine justice it gains a higher dignity; if it is only seen as a compulsive framework it becomes burdensome. The ordinary citizen who envies tyrants, the tyrant himself, and the wise stranger, all share in common an interpretation of the law as a man-made edifice which one wishes to go beyond. The ordinary gentleman, the statesman, and the wise citizen, are alike in regarding human law as a representation, however incomplete, of divine law and seeking to honour it. The former type of wise man sees the latter type as, perhaps, delusional with regards to what can be deduced regarding the character of the cosmos. The latter type of wise man sees the former as not fully detached from human concerns, namely, the preferencing of the demands of honor to attention to the eternal problems. Strauss writes: “the philosopher as such is concerned with nothing but the quest for wisdom and kindling or nourishing the love of wisdom in those who are by nature capable of it... insofar as the philosopher, owing to the weakness of the flesh, becomes concerned with being recognized by others, he ceases to be a philosopher. According to the strict view of the classics, he turns into a sophist” (203).

Let us explore further the position of the pious or philosophic wise man. We may observe that in the very reasoning which differentiates “love” (desire to be passionately praised by the indiscriminate many) from “honour” (desire to be admired by the capable few) a further reach is implied: the maximum headway an individual can make away from the sensual pleasures and mass-recognition toward awareness of the eternal problems. As one approaches this far reach, requiring less preoccupation with the recognition of others, it follows that there would be a corresponding lack of

capable judges. This wise man's pleasure comes from his own recognition of his increasing degrees of progress toward wisdom. At this point, whoever it is that seeks out and achieves such a superior awareness would stand above *all* men – real men and human beings both. He would be in a position to best recognize that the standard “real man” contains within itself the truth that men, as much as they are distinguished by intellect (“real”), also in an important way brothers (“man”) (190). While one might have expected such a type, who recognizes the distinction between justice and law, to lead a life of cosmopolitan individualism, he instead re-immerses himself in the city. He does not, like Simonides, show a particular preference for the solitary delights such as food and drink. His detachment from human beings becomes again compatible with attachment to human beings. While the philosopher subsumes parochial concerns to the investigation of perennial or eternal problems, he is nevertheless an excellent citizen. He has no interest in “getting more;” he has a compassion which extends to all human beings he comes into contact with; and “[s]ince he fully realizes the limits set to all human action and all human planning (for what has come into being must perish again), he does not expect salvation or satisfaction from the establishment of the simply best social order... [h]e will therefore not engage in revolutionary or subversive activity” (200). He will try to help his fellow man by mitigating evils as much as possible (perhaps mitigating such millenarian expectation in particular), and to this end will become a political philosopher so that he can converse with political men.

The philosopher engages in political action, but of a limited and specific kind. He will, as mentioned above, do his basic political duty of providing the insight which is most obvious to him but least obvious to the unwise with which he converses: the tempering of expectations which exceed the bounds of human potentiality or natural limit. As well, since he is attracted to the souls of young potential philosophers, or kindred spirits, he must compete for their education against those who would corrupt their potential. Because this education involves drawing the young away from the ideals held by the unwise, and because the philosophic always have a dubious reputation due to the actions of the

sophist, these educative attempts will themselves be perceived as corruption. In part due to pressure resulting from this situation, the philosopher will speak and act with the intention of “satisfying the city that the philosophers are not atheists, that they do not desecrate everything sacred to the city, that they reverence what the city reverences, that they are not subversives, in short that they are not irresponsible adventurers but good citizens and even the best of citizens” (206). All of this is to say that it is not necessary for the philosopher's politics to overlap with the politics of the ruler. The philosophic type of wise man does return to the city, but his return is qualified by his continued allegiance to what lies beyond the city.

Above the stratum of the unwise, there is the world of the wise occupied by two types: the sophist, and the philosopher. Both recognize a standard of value that can not be justified in terms of pleasure. For the sophist, it is the value of being a real man, of being honoured by other real men. The philosopher points beyond honour, to the standard of wisdom, for which it is possible that one receives no accolades and has to derive their pleasure from their own awareness of their progress. The sophist chooses to live as a stranger, contemptuous of human law. The philosopher lives as a citizen, regarding law as, at least as a possibility, a salutary reflection of justice or divine order.

Through Strauss' interpretation, *Hiero* is a structured microcosm of the classic position viewed from the outside, i.e. from the perspective of “ordinary ambiguity,” and in particular from the perspective, not of the ordinary gentleman, but of the ordinary citizen who understands the pleasure coming from being loved to be the sole standard of preference. By looking through the world-view which sees tyranny as the most desirable life we receive a rendition of the teaching of the philosopher which is most extreme: on the surface is the message that one should pursue virtue not for its own sake but for its rewards, or be beneficent tyrants, which contains a further teaching which suggests the preferability of the life of a wise stranger, which itself only hints at the possible existence of the wise citizen. In addition to the fact that the preference for honour over love suggests a possible further

threshold of self-sufficiency which points back to civic responsibility, Xenophon himself, operating from the background, never ultimately abandons the presuppositions of the philosopher. Strauss writes that the “reason why the *Hiero* comes so close to the *Prince* is that in the *Hiero* Xenophon experiments with a type of wisdom which comes relatively close to a wisdom divorced from moderation” (184-185). Xenophon comes as close as possible without finally leaving the bounds of Socratic thought.

2. Machiavelli and the UHS

Machiavelli considered his teaching to be so wholly new as to be tantamount to the discovery of a new continent, and Strauss believes he is correct (*What is Political Philosophy?* 40). The shift in attitudes effected as mankind began to colonize this new continent was not achieved in Machiavelli's name, for Machiavelli's teaching was too blasphemous or “revolting” to function for pedestrian purposes or to appeal to gentlemen (47-48). It was developed through the lineage of thinkers such as Hobbes, Locke, Rousseau, and so on, who mitigated Machiavelli's language while maintaining his core teaching: namely, that man must not take his bearings from “dreamed up republic and principalities” but from the basic exigencies of concrete existence. While a sophist such as Protagoras was able to suggest that “man is the measure of all things,” and that the essentially arbitrary *nomos* ought to be guarded like the walls of the city for the sake of political stability, he was still unable to distance his teaching from the taint of dubious variations by men such as Thrasymachus and Gorgias. Machiavelli was able to initiate a teaching whose substance was along similar lines yet which was able to secure a most humane or gentlemanly reputation. Machiavelli's success may be attributed, first, to his recognition, contrary to the sophists, that speech must be supplemented by force (*History* 316), or that, when speaking of the bestial element in man's centaur nature, the 'fox' must be accompanied by the 'lion'. Machiavelli emphasizes persuasion supplemented by arms, or concrete motivators. He therefore

distances himself from the apparent seediness and cheap sorcery of the study of persuasive speech simply, while offering an apparently sober-eyed program for the establishment of political order. Second, Machiavelli operates in a political climate receptive to an alternative approach to the problem of political stability. The mode of political engagement consistent with reverence for the divine had reason to be re-examined. Christianity refined the account of the believer to a greater extent than ever experienced in the Greek milieu. By Machiavelli's time, the Church had supplemented its "spiritual" power with considerable "temporal" involvement, making accusations of bad faith, with a world-view to correspond, inevitable. Let us set aside for now the question of the root of Machiavelli's teaching and consider only the effects of his modification.

Machiavelli's project is, broadly speaking, to close the gulf between "how one should live and how one does live", or in other words to align one's projects with the reality indicated by the inconsistencies between what people say or believe versus what they actually do or must do (*Prince* 91). His prescriptions derive from what is his implicit ontological speculation, by which the dependence of man's loftier attitudes (virtuous behaviour, love) upon what are considered lower things (necessities of survival, fear, desires) is indicative of the primacy, truth, or authority of these lower things. The loftier does not merely depend on the lower as a precondition, it indicates the ugly truth – that the lofty is nothing but a veneer of the base. Machiavelli's teaching, then, is to recognize that the operation of the lower things constitutes the true operations of reality and to design one's projects in accordance with the lower things.

One's ability to practice traditional virtue is subsidiary to the material stability of one's person or regime. If a man practices virtue exclusively in a world of other men, who in general are "wretched creatures", "ungrateful, fickle, liars, and deceivers," cowardly and greedy, he will come to ruin (101, 96). He should always "appear to be compassionate, faithful to his word, kind, guileless, and devout", and indeed be so to the extent possible. Yet this being so is limited by the constant exigencies of

stability, which must always be attended to, even in times of calm (130). Virtuous behaviour is further limited in as much as “stability,” or acquisition and fortification of foundational goods, also seems to include the base desires such as “getting more”, which by its nature is insatiable (42). The first term of rule, in which one establishes one's state, may be represented by the Roman emperor Maximus Severus, who quickly moved up the ranks and usurped the throne with open violence and treachery, and the second term, in which one maintains and glorifies the state, by Marcus Aurelius, a magnanimous ruler whose success depended on his hereditary right to the throne (114); the illegitimate usurper eases into the guise of legitimacy. Ascription to the lower things motivate one to always find the available means, or adopt the appropriate *mode*, of seeming to be guided by the loftier things. One must cultivate an image of traditional virtue (the most important facet of the image being the religious virtues) behind which one not only stabilizes one's rule but acquires as much of the desirable objects as possible – that is, riches and glory (101, 125, 131). Machiavelli displays new confidence in the ability to secure such rule by advising the adoption of an attitude of mastery against the forces of natural disorder.

As indicated earlier in reference to the lineage of modern thought, this change in orientation can be adapted and have its accents shifted so as to appear most decent and humane. The emphases on acquisition and deception can be softened so that the imperative of the project becomes to communicate to all human beings the truth that the lofty things are illusory and that unscrupulous men would seek to harness these illusions for their own gain. This does not alter Machiavelli's core presupposition that the loftier things don't merely presuppose or depend on the lower or basic things but are of a less fundamental reality than them. We may gain perspective on the import of this civilizational commitment effected by Machiavelli by comparing his advice to the new prince against Xenophon's Simonides' advice to Hiero.

As with Simonides, Machiavelli (the wise man) engages with a tyrant-ruler (the new prince). The new prince is revealed as an absolute ruler by the fact that the legality of his means of securing or

maintaining power is beside the point (50). The laws are not authoritative for this man. The new prince only with great caution tampers with the constitution of the regime, but he compensates for this by learning to manipulate it from the background. Simonides indicates to the tyrant to present himself as a ruler and to conceal his unseemly activities. Machiavelli achieves the same effect by different means: he discloses to the man bearing political power his absolute power of agency while reminding him to mask this motive. Both Simonides and Machiavelli, then, deal with a tyrant-ruler or, according to the “theoretical thesis concerning tyranny,” rulers in the generic sense – the political type of man, or even representatives of the unwise type generally – who seek to be loved by the mass. Hiero and the new prince are the same in this respect. The interests of both can be expressed in terms of the economical acquisition of love – some combination of pleasure and honour. Both only seek the advice of a man who shows himself to be shrewd and hardboiled and as such as having an excellent grasp of the political things. Both are suspicious that the wise adviser himself is a potential usurper to be kept at arm's length (127). Both are advised to arm their subjects and to make their city prosperous, or to draw one's regime into one's personage and to prepare for the international battle for glory.

On the second level, we examine the wise men in question, who harbour a deeper theoretical understanding than those with whom they converse. As Simonides' distinction from Hiero is communicated by the former's preference for honour over love, it is the ambivalent role of glory in Machiavelli which reveals the disparity between his own perceptions and the advice suggested to his prince. On one hand, Machiavelli writes that “it cannot be called prowess to kill fellow citizens, to betray friends, to be treacherous, pitiless, irreligious. These ways can win a prince power but not glory” (63), and cites both money *and* glory as the fundamental desires. Glory seems to stand as a standard of excellence requiring one to provide a justification beyond the hedonistic getting-more of pleasure. On the other hand, at other times, he speaks of glory in terms of “profit,” as if glory was subsidiary to pleasure (120). The lofty things are secondary to the lower things, and is not glory a lofty thing? On

what grounds could Machiavelli rebuke the hedonist who shirks glory to engage in the sensual pleasures? To the extent that Machiavelli would wish to hold glory as something substantial he indicates that he himself is of a different caliber than the new prince he advises. Strauss points to this discrepancy when he notes that:

the *Discourses* state powerfully the case for republics while also instructing potential tyrants in how to destroy republican life. Yet there can hardly be any doubts that Machiavelli preferred republics to monarchies, tyrannical or nontyrannical. He loathed oppression which is not in the service of the well-being of the people and hence of effective government, especially of impartial and unsqueamish punitive justice. He was a generous man, while knowing very well that what passes for generosity in political life is most of the time nothing but shrewd calculation, which as such deserves to be commended. (*History*, 314-15)

Machiavelli, like Simonides, gives the apparently hardboiled advice to his interlocutor to pursue beneficent tyranny for the sake of self-interest. This is not inconsistent with the possibility that Machiavelli believes this regime to be a good social order (i.e. a tyranny not “bad for the city”), or that Machiavelli himself admits or tries to admit somewhere a loftier standard than the low simply. Machiavelli advises a “tyrant” but with the intention of stabilizing a republic. Both Simonides and Machiavelli are more politically well-intentioned than they may at first seem.

So far we have identified the similarities between Simonides-Hiero and Machiavelli-Prince. With the purpose of transposing Machiavelli against the classic position, the *Hiero* allows a further remove – recourse to Xenophon himself who in his standing as a Socratic (citizen-wise man) is concealed behind his Simonides (stranger-wise man). It is the influence of the Socratic Xenophon which ultimately accounts for the key *differences* between Simonides-Hiero and Machiavelli-Prince. If Xenophon's experiments with divorcing wisdom from moderation are what accounts for the closeness

of *Hiero* to *The Prince*, it is the subtle but persisting influence of that moderation which marks their ultimate incongruity (*On Tyranny*, 184-185).

First, Xenophon's Simonides' distinction of the phenomenon of honour is more defined than it is in Machiavelli. Simonides affirms it as *the* characteristic of a superior kind of man, the *real man*. Since the preference of the standards of the real man to those of the human being cannot be justified in terms of an economy of pleasure alone, this preference necessitates the existence of a separate standard of value. It indicates, at least, a trajectory from the indiscriminate enjoyment of sensual pleasures to the discriminate enjoyment of the recognition of one's excellence. Yet, still more, it subtly indicates the logical possibility of a further reach. This is the enjoyment of the essentially self-assessed pleasure of one's progress toward wisdom, or the eternal problems. Machiavelli collapses the desires for honour and pleasure such that the distinction between the respective lives and values they imply are muddled, and the potential existence of a philosophic type is almost completely obscured.

Second, the dialogue form rather than the treatise better conveys ambivalence such that a surface reading is tempered at the same time as a concealed meaning is indicated. A treatise less readily suggests layers of meaning, where even the surface reader of the *Hiero* is likely to take its apparent teaching with a grain of salt. At the same time, Simonides' subtle dialectical mastery, in convincing the tyrant that they are of both of the same kind, when the dynamics of the dialogue quietly suggest that they are not, does not go unnoticed by the careful reader and suggests the importance of investigation in general. Machiavelli is far more straightforward. As such, his advice is more likely to be taken at face value or on its surface reading, which is narrower than the complete teaching of the *Hiero*. Xenophon is careful to indicate by deed the importance of good rhetoric, of burying between the lines subtler teachings which would be liable to be misinterpreted by those who do not notice them. Machiavelli does not reveal the same sensitivity; his preference for republics to tyrannies is not as well sustained by the “deed” of his text's structure.

Third, Simonides only gives his advice to a ruler already considered a tyrant – who has already demonstrated a disrespect for the law. Machiavelli's advice can appeal to powerful statesmen who by disposition respect law or divine law. As such, Xenophon's Simonides manifestly demonstrates a prudence or preference for the sanctity of established legitimate order which Machiavelli does not.

Finally, the advice able to be extrapolated from the *Hiero* is of a far different kind than the advice able to be extrapolated from *The Prince*. As mentioned, the advice given to Hiero by Simonides, and hence to the “properly equipped young men who are pondering what way of life they should choose” (*On Tyranny* 30), is buffered from being put into practice by the grain of salt of its seeming inapplicability. Machiavelli states his intention as “to say something that will prove of practical use to the inquirer” (*Prince* 90). As well, Machiavelli's surface teaching is more destructive of tradition than Xenophon's; Simonides does not provide an ontological floorplan that would have to be the case for Hiero's preferences to be correct -- which Machiavelli comes nearer to doing -- and is also careful to only show his lack of scruple, or impiety, by his silence. Where Xenophon was merely “experimenting” with the surface teaching encouraging beneficent tyranny but still operating within the bounds of Socratic thought, Machiavelli considers his similar teaching to be reflective of newly discovered truth. He is less wary of the consequences of providing an account of being that does away with the lofty things. His account is concerned with the “armed” shaping of concrete phenomena toward one's interests. The net effect of Machiavelli's adjustment is that he endorses the taking of concrete steps in accord with the account of being he provides. Xenophon's Simonides frustrates this impulse. With these differences in mind, let us consider more deeply the political consequences of Machiavelli's adjustment.

Now, according to the classic position, wise men of all kinds are motivated to engage in politics. The sophist seeks the remuneration and recognition which comes from working with influential clients, and the philosopher must find a way to pay his keep, must defend his activity, and

must engage in a struggle for the destinies of kindred spirits. The philosopher's political activity, however, is only partial: from the necessity of his political engagement does not follow the necessity of his contributing to the best regime's instantiation on earth (*On Tyranny* 205). The philosopher does not want to rule as rulership is tedious work which would disrupt his efforts to develop his own wisdom, i.e., would undermine his very standing as a philosopher. The trade-off is that he must advise men who are not wise and as such are bound to misinterpret his teachings or appropriate from them only what they will. Namely, they are interested in acquiring love or pleasure by establishing the best earthly regime, unreceptive to that reality indicated by its inability to be expressed or accounted for in terms of pleasure. Strauss writes that the defense of philosophy – the philosopher's essential political activity – was achieved by Plato with “resounding success”, such that “[o]ne sometimes wonders whether it has not been too successful” (206). The successful defense of philosophy was received by and connected to the theoretical underpinnings of Christianity. Machiavelli reacts to Christianity's increasing “temporal” influence, not by indicating the lack of salvation or satisfaction to be expected from the establishment of the simply best social order (200), but by distilling the tendency toward temporal influence into an original principle. His solution does not *restore* the proper relationship between thought and action, but rather *consummates* the tendency by abolishing the distinction altogether.

Machiavelli's teaching initiates a change into how rulers interact with wise men. Machiavelli has sanctioned the establishment of a robust unbounded regime on the basis of the aggrandizement of the agent. The ruler is no longer limited by ineffable considerations, or the riddling counsel of more traditional wise men. He may therefore get to building the regime consistent with the teachings of his wise adviser.

The teachings of his new adviser directly contradict the teachings of his former adviser. They say, in effect, that the wise man who fancied himself a philosopher, or who spoke of ineffable limits and a piety disconnected from self-interest strictly, was deluded, himself merely a piquant breed of

honour-seeker. The new adviser tells the ruler how to dismiss the philosopher's lofty claims, and to go about strengthening one's regime as one's sole imperative. As such, as this regime is progressively instated, the requirements of life for philosophic type of wise man, or philosophic aspect of men in general, are increasingly disregarded as considerations. But the philosopher is of a resilient kind. He crops up in many regimes, all of which, according to the “theoretical thesis concerning tyranny”, are imperfect implementations of justice. The reason the UHS is different requires further elaboration.

Xenophon distinguishes between two kinds of wise man: the wise stranger, and the wise citizen. Strauss marks, in accord with “the strict view of the classics,” the former as the sophist and the latter as the philosopher (203). The mystery of the philosopher is that in his forays past seeking the love of the many, past seeking the honours of the few, into his self-directed expeditions, he does not choose to live as an alien. He returns to the city, and abides by its imperfect laws, so long as they are not in stark contradiction of justice. Where the sophistic type views the imperfect laws as compulsions, the philosopher views them as reflections or possible reflections of a divine order. The (wise) sophist, the (unwise) tyrant, and the (unwise) ordinary citizen are alike in sharing the former disposition, and viewing law as necessary for order but as something one would wish to escape. The (wise) philosopher, the (unwise) statesman, and the (unwise) gentlemen are alike in sharing the latter disposition, or seeing imperfect man-made law as nevertheless representative of divine beneficence. However, *all* of the unwise, whether attracted to tyranny or law, are alike in sharing a preference for love from the many, against praise by the qualified few. The statesman and the ordinary gentleman are simply aware before the fact that this is best achieved by servitude or beneficence. As they are not wise, they are not privy to the rational foundations of their position; the gentleman in the political or social sense is not a true gentleman – or in other words, as cautioned in the myth of Er, he is a gentleman more vulnerable than he knows to the seductions of tyranny (182). Wisdom is required for true gentlemanliness (42). The two types of wise men display different kinds of gentlemanliness, or inborn acts of beneficence. The

sophist, acknowledging honour or glory as his motive, and understanding the cosmos to be a godless order which requires political order to be forcibly imposed for the sake of socializing human beings, transmits his understanding so that this order can best be constructed. At the same time, he wishes to live outside of this order as a stranger, or a man above the laws. The philosopher, pursuing wisdom simply, seems to recognize in the cosmos the potential for a *beneficent* order which permeates and is made visible by the framework of good laws. His return to the city to live as a good citizen is a manifest show of his faith. The philosophic type of wise man alone is the shepherd of piety. He alone shows by deed the possibility of a good beyond power-operations. In other words, he is the sole support of the view that the economy of pleasure is not a comprehensive framework of analysis. The ordinary gentleman's gentlemanliness is only an image, or an unwise man's attempt at representation, of this original gesture of piety.

Machiavelli is a new kind of sophist. While he does not believe in the lofty speculations of the philosopher, he creates a teaching which lends itself to the establishment of a robust political order. His teaching is successful since it escapes the taint that dogged the ancient sophists, and can eventually appeal, not only to those shackled by the stigma of “tyrant,” but to law-abiding gentleman statesmen. Simonides' advice to Hiero was utopian not only because Hiero was unlikely to listen to his interlocutor, but because his title made the application of the advice impractical. Machiavelli's advice to the new prince is applicable because the new prince begins with an outward appearance of legitimacy. Machiavelli appeals to the sense of agency latent in every statesman. The teaching, in effect, transforms the gentleman statesman into an absolute ruler not recognized as such. The realm suggested by Xenophon and Machiavelli is able to be put into practice by Machiavelli's prince, but this at the precise expense of the ruler's following the advice of a sophist and not a philosopher.

This has a consequence for the kind of law that develops in the prince's regime. Machiavelli's advice presupposes that the philosopher's journeys are illusory. Yet the philosopher's manifest gesture

of piety is the sole act of faith that signals that *laws* may be more than mere *rules*. It is the irreconcilable distinction between justice and law, or between theory and practice, which testifies to the fact that *honour* and *wisdom* provide separate frameworks of analysis from *pleasure* alone. It is the precise shortcoming of the sophist to be short-sighted regarding the consequences of eroding these distinctions. The consequence is that the unwise construct a world which shuts out, as much as possible, the philosopher's role as a herald of justice. The laws in the prince's regime are least *laws* and most *rules* of any possible human legislature. They attempt to instate what is a re coined conception of "justice" as the degree to which the material world matches the rational principle that the low is prior to the lofty. This volatilizes even the sophist's attempt at prioritizing honour. Assuming the value of the philosopher's position, then, because the laws to the maximum degree possible shut out the influence of extra-worldly justice, they are illegitimate to the maximum degree possible. The prince's regime is "lawless," a tyranny. The UHS is a tyranny built by ordinary gentlemen who have been advised by a sophist. It is least permeable to the perception that the law is salutary to a divine justice that indicates a cosmos in which selfless action is possible and the eternal is connected to the temporal, and most suggestive of a reality in which the lofty is always collapsing to the low. This understanding of justice results in the progressive instantiation of a *nomos* which by design does not only preside over politics and oppress its opposing view, as all previous regimes have done, but acts in opposition to its perennial opponent with maximum precision and efficacy. In the best possibility this would involve the concrete annihilation of the sources of this opposition, and in the worst the enslavement of these energies within the circuits of an immaterial power system.

The dynamic described can be expressed in more elemental terms. The practicing statesman, or amplified ordinary gentleman, according to the typology of the classics, longs to be universally loved. He is intuitively aware that this requires him to be a benefactor. According to Simonides, this goal (which could never be accomplished) compels him to extend his regime worldwide (win the

international contest for glory) and make all of the citizens happy. This impulse is mitigated by the transmissions of the philosopher which the gentleman encounters and is moved by. The philosopher's advice is always in accord with preserving the philosophic way of life which depends on the insight that thought is distinct from action. It is a fool's errand to attempt to make every human being happy; happiness depends on wisdom and wisdom is only open to the few. Yet, the political man is always suspicious that the philosopher secretly has tyrannical ambitions. It is this suspicion which his adviser activates when he provides the political man with the formula to instate earthly justice – the ultimate gesture of beneficence or of securing love. The philosopher has always been inhibiting this action. The sophist, besides sanctioning the project of global dominion, gives particular suggestions to his conversant, the absolute ruler or tyrant lying latent in every law-abiding political man. These are to stabilize rule by turning all political things into economic competitions and games, which serves the effect of distracting the men with classic pretensions of courage and justice; to present the enforcers of the regime as peace-keepers; and for the agent to hold himself as a respectable authority. The ruler is advised to build such a realm, in accord with the ontological principles not of the philosopher but the sophist.

The political man, acting in good faith, “must suppress philosophy as an attempt to corrupt the young. In particular he must... forbid every teaching, every suggestion, that there are politically relevant natural differences among men which cannot be abolished or neutralized by progressing scientific technology” (211). Because of “the conquest of nature and... the complete unabashed substitution of suspicion and terror for law” the ruler is able to thoroughly persecute all philosophers, as the tyrant-makers it perceives them to be. The irony is that not only do wise men have no desire to rule since, to say the least, they consider the pursuit of universal gratitude futile, but that the philosophic type of wise man is the courier of the piety which is responsible for endowing ordinary gentlemanliness with its nobility. It is this air of nobility which eventually allows the gentleman-

statesman to operate as a ruler while bearing legitimate standing. Once he receives the sophist's blessing, the gentleman-statesman is able to attempt to consummate his longing. The longing of the statesman or the gentleman, however, is at bottom the same as the longing of the vulgar ordinary citizen or the tyrant. The project the gentleman is building is no less than the beneficent face belying his exaggerated image or indictment of tyranny. It is not the fantasy of the crook but the no less tyrannical fantasy of the decent but unwise citizen.

There is an important corollary to the fact that the UHS is built not by a tyrant but by gentlemen. We would expect a tyranny to have figurehead. Yet a figurehead would not seem to be commensurate with the kind of reduced happiness consistent with the project to establish the UHS, i.e. "satisfaction deriving from universal recognition" (210). Dissatisfaction exists to the extent that one human being is arbitrarily more recognized than another. To this point, Kojève makes clear that "[i]n the final state there naturally are no more "human beings"... The tyrant becomes an administrator, a cog in the "machine" fashioned by automata for automata" (255). Where the flesh-and-blood tyrant siphons resources away from the city for his own sake, the gentleman-ruler establishes in good faith a *political system* which siphons resources away for the purpose of its own success and upkeep. Its power is not localized within a single human being. All human beings would be equally recognized.

Yet, what in the end would limit the state's universality and homogeneity? Why would the human form or the political state persist? Kojève indeed confirms that it would not. Love in contradistinction to wisdom is characterized by a preoccupation with one's own or the proximal, and this includes both time and space. The ruler is driven to establish a comprehensive eternal present. The limiting factor of this project is the pressure provided by underlying reality. How this inevitable conflict would occur is unclear.

Strauss suggests that the mystery of the philosopher, the sign of his beneficence, is that he for all practical purposes identifies justice with legality, while simultaneously understanding justice to be beyond the law. A parallel mystery concerns piety, or “knowledge of the laws concerning the gods”. “Socrates was so pious that he would do nothing without the consent of the gods,” and yet his means of making his companions pious was by “making them consider the purposeful character of the universe and its parts” (104). Strauss reads this method of *intimating* piety as virtually denying its *definition*. In other words, conveying the existence of divine law through an intimation of the mechanistic elegance of the universe is hardly a demonstration: the relation is inexplicable to the skeptic who does not share this experience of mechanism. Machiavelli's success where even the well-intentioned sophists fell short was due to his emphasis on supplementing persuasive speech with concrete action. Where the ancient sophists could be refuted by an appeal to natural limit, i.e. geometry, as limiting the efficacy of persuasive speech, this same refutation is not applicable to the new strain of sophistry initiated by Machiavelli. The new sophist agrees that the world has mechanistic elegance but not that this implies any indication of the divine. He has come into his own as an opponent and can not only hold a stalemate so that the philosopher can not achieve dialectical victory, but enjoys the advantage of being able to point to the material prosperity resulting from his suggestions – a most persuasive gesture. His advice is tempting to the mass of unwise men who are driven by the desire to be loved, and the philosopher can no longer forward a demonstrably superior argument.

Machiavelli's political advice is given clout by the availability of geometry's increasingly sophisticated and applicable schematizations of the material world. So that the situation of universal homogeneity is not viewed in an inappropriately tragic light, we may wonder at the fact that the progressive development or accrual of geometric knowledge seems in the very nature of things to be inevitable. Therefore, in the spirit of Xenophon, who wrote that “it is both noble and just, and pious

and more pleasant to remember the good things rather than the bad ones” the role of the trajectory toward the UHS may be considered within the greater context of the whole.